

What is marriage?

Mark 7:7

Howbeit in vain do they worship me, teaching for doctrines the commandments of men.

Our perspective can easily be twisted and wrong because of the lies that the world teaches us. Sometimes, those lies become entrenched in **our** tradition and if we're not careful they creep into the body of Christ (the Church).

Be vigilant and continually remember that the world is the enemy of God.

James 4:4

Ye adulterers and adulteresses, know ye not that the friendship of the world is enmity with God? whosoever therefore will be a friend of the world is the enemy of God.

And, if we aren't careful we can then take that tradition and apply it to scripture causing us to err in our judgment. In the following example we're going to look at a tradition based on a lie that is so deeply embedded into human culture and nearly every nation on the planet that you might even be offended, hurt, or upset to learn that we've so easily accepted this lie hook, line, and sinker for thousands of years. Prepare yourself for that.

Take the following scenario:

A virgin, "unmarried in the traditional sense", man and woman have intercourse together. Most people would condemn them and say "you need to get married" and most other people would agree with them. Unfortunately for those people, there's a huge problem with that judgment in God's word: they're already married. Therefore, those people have condemned the guiltless.

Seems contradictory right? They need to get married but they're already married. That's because it is. In that example there are two ideals at odds with each other: one is of the world and the other is of God. One is wrong and one is right. The important questions to ask yourself are: which is which and how can we prove that with God's word?

Let's start with the easy part we all know because we've all been taught the same from birth. It's so ingrained into human culture that every nation on the planet seems to have evolved **their own** style of it (anytime we see many different "styles" or "flavors" of a particular thing that should be a red flag: God's way is always **one** way and it **never** needs to change because it's already pure and perfect. Conversely, the world continually needs to evolve and change because it does not have the power of God which satisfies [John 4:14](#)).

So, how does the world define marriage? It usually involves a feast, a ceremony, and then some licensed official declares the couple married and then they give them a piece of paper stating as such. Now they're married right? In the eyes of the world? Yes. But, in the eyes of God? **No**.

You may be surprised to find out that God doesn't define marriage the same way as the world. So, let's have a careful look at how God defines marriage in scripture. We'll start with the very first time that the word "wife" appears in the Bible because it is the only example we'll ever need; however, we'll also expand out from there to mitigate any possible doubt.

Genesis 2:21-25

²¹ And the LORD God caused a deep sleep to fall upon Adam, and he slept: and he took one of his ribs, and closed up the flesh instead thereof;

²² And the rib, which the LORD God had taken from man, made he a woman, and brought her unto the man.

²³ And Adam said, This is now bone of my bones, and flesh of my flesh: she shall be called Woman, because she was taken out of Man.

²⁴ Therefore shall a man leave his father and his mother, and shall cleave unto his wife: and they shall be one flesh.

²⁵ And they were both naked, the man and his wife, and were not ashamed.

Do take note that v24 is all **future** tense (it's not chronologically speaking about Adam & Eve but instead it speaks towards **all** men) and it's a three step process:

1. The man leaves his father and his mother.
2. He cleaves unto his wife (to take, keep, stay close to, join together, follow closely, stick together; the word "cleave" **does not** communicate intercourse).
3. The man and his wife become one flesh (this is the physical joining, what we would call intercourse, mating, copulation, or sex; see below for verses that prove this).

v25 is where things get interesting. It's the first time that Eve is called Adam's wife in the **past** tense. That means at that point God considered Adam and Eve to be husband and wife (married). No ceremony, no papers, and also no intercourse *that we know of from this context**. We do know that they were already *one flesh* in the sense that Eve was literally created from a part taken from Adam's flesh. But, what about every subsequent human and what about the context we learn from elsewhere in scripture?

The phrase "*one flesh*" appears seven times in six verses in the Bible: [Genesis 2:24](#), [Matthew 19:5,6](#), [Mark 10:8](#), [1 Corinthians 6:16](#), [Ephesians 5:31](#). Every one of them contributes something to the idea of what it means to be "*one flesh*".

Genesis 2:24

Therefore shall a man leave his father and his mother, and shall cleave unto his wife: **and they shall be one flesh.**

When a man and woman stick close together they (future tense) shall be one flesh.

What naturally happens when a man and a woman stick very close to each other for any length of time? Whether they actually perform the act of intercourse together or not they certainly at least think about it. That "natural attraction" is exactly why men and woman feel the need to be "separated" from each other.

Matthew 19:3-6

³ The Pharisees also came unto him, tempting him, and saying unto him, Is it lawful for a man to put away his wife for every cause?

⁴ And he answered and said unto them, **Have ye not read, that he which made them at the beginning made them male and female,**

⁵ **And said, For this cause shall a man leave father and mother, and shall cleave to his wife: and they twain shall be one flesh?**

⁶ **Wherefore they are no more twain, but one flesh. What therefore God hath joined together, let not man put asunder.**

God does the joining (the context is physical).

Mark 10:2-9 ² And the Pharisees came to him, and asked him, Is it lawful for a man to put away his wife? tempting him. ³ And he answered and said unto them, What did Moses command you? ⁴ And they said, Moses suffered to write a bill of divorcement, and to put her away. ⁵ And Jesus answered and said unto them, For the hardness of your heart he wrote you this precept. ⁶ But from the beginning of the creation God made them male and female. ⁷ For this cause shall a man leave his father and mother, and cleave to his wife; ⁸ And they twain shall be one flesh: so then they are no more twain, but one flesh. ⁹ What therefore God hath joined together, let not man put asunder.	Something happens when a man and a woman stick close to each other that causes them to go from “two fleshes” (twain) to “one flesh”. God does the joining (the context is physical).
1 Corinthians 6:15-16 ¹⁵ Know ye not that your bodies are the members of Christ? shall I then take the members of Christ, and make them the members of an harlot? God forbid. ¹⁶ What? know ye not that he which is joined to an harlot is one body? for two, saith he, shall be one flesh.	*Two bodies joining together is the same as becoming “one flesh”. This also necessarily tells us that chronologically Genesis 4:1a occurred before Genesis 2:25. This is the most explicit verse that tells us that “becoming one flesh” is the same as “joining together” which is the same as “intercourse/mating/copulating/sex”.
Ephesians 5:28-33 ²⁸ So ought men to love their wives as their own bodies. He that loveth his wife loveth himself. ²⁹ For no man ever yet hated his own flesh; but nourisheth and cherisheth it, even as the Lord the church: ³⁰ For we are members of his body, of his flesh, and of his bones. ³¹ For this cause shall a man leave his father and mother, and shall be joined unto his wife, and they two shall be one flesh. ³² This is a great mystery: but I speak concerning Christ and the church. ³³ Nevertheless let every one of you in particular so love his wife even as himself; and the wife see that she reverence her husband.	Note that the context is husbands and wives (they’re already married). A man should love, cherish, and nourish his wife as if it were is own flesh because they are one flesh.

And that’s all we really need to look at because try as we might we will never find in scripture God prescribing or commanding a feast, ceremony, and/or legal document to testify that two people are now married. In fact, all that we find is what I have shown you: intercourse **is marriage** in God’s eyes. The feasts, the ceremonies, the rituals, the legal documents: that was all invented by men and passed down through the traditions of men.

And now that we have gathered the information we need from scripture we can look at the two ideals that clash with each other in the first example side by side:

Marriage	
God's eyes	Man's eyes
One flesh, coming together, joining together, knowing one another, intercourse, copulation, mating, sex	A feast and/or a ceremony and/or a ritual and/or a legal document

When making any judgment ([John 7:24](#)), which do you think is right according to God?

Therefore, the next time we look at an “unmarried in the traditional sense” couple that have had intercourse together we should consider carefully God's perspective first: they're already married (whether that marriage was fornication or adultery is a different matter). The feasts, the ceremonies, the legal documents: none of that will count for anything in the judgment ([Proverbs 29:26](#), [Hebrew 9:27](#)). What will matter is condemning innocent people.